MODULE-2 · MASTERCLASS DOSSIER

2.3 The Format Scoring System

Lesson masterclass · implementation drills · war-room directive

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Score stations by playlist evidence rather than format label rumor.
- Plot tempo, energy, and era from real stream logs.
- Rank your shortlist like an analyst, not a fan.

★ **INSIDER RADIO TIP**

Score the playlist, not the website. Pull the last 10–15 songs a station actually plays via stream logs and plot tempo, energy and era — that ‘neighborhood’ is your real target definition.

▲ **THE OPERATOR MOVE**

If a station’s stream log sits on the boundary of your genre, that’s a specialty-slot lead, not a power miss. Hunt the edges first.

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2.3 The Format Scoring System — Rank Every Station Like an Analyst

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THE ONE-LINE TRUTH: Format fit accounts for 50% of every programming rejection. Scoring stations with mathematical rigor prevents you from wasting A-tier pitches on zero-probability rooms.

MASTERCLASS DIRECTIVE & STRATEGIC BLUEPRINT

Strategic Foundation & Operational Reality

The most demoralizing experience in music promotion is sending 100 passionate emails and receiving 100 deafening silences. When this happens, artists inevitably conclude that their art is inadequate. In 90% of cases, the music was never the issue; the campaign suffered from catastrophic **format misalignment**.

Radio formats are rigid, mathematically optimized consumer products. An Urban Contemporary programmer will not play an Americana folk ballad, no matter how emotionally profound the lyrics are. A Classical public station will not air an 808-heavy trap single.

To eliminate wasted effort, Dominion operators evaluate every prospective station through a clinical **100-Point Format Scoring System** across six weighted factors before a single email is dispatched.

The Six Weighted Scoring Factors (100-Point Scale)

1. **Genre & Sonic Architecture Compatibility (30 Points Max):** Does your song's instrumentation, tempo, vocal production, and dynamic range match the current charting records on the station's playlist?

- 30 pts: Perfect sonic twin of core charting rotation.
- 20 pts: Compatible sub-genre fitting evening specialty blocks.
- 10 pts: Marginal fit requiring specialized programming context.
- 0 pts: Glaring format clash.

1. **Geographic Proximity & Regional Equity (20 Points Max):** Station proximity to your home market or active tour corridor.

- 20 pts: Ring 1 home city or active local venue market.
- 15 pts: Ring 2 commuter zone (30-90 miles).
- 10 pts: Ring 3 regional tour corridor.
- 0 pts: Distant market with zero tour or regional narrative.

1. **Verified Individual Human Contact (15 Points Max):** Quality of gatekeeper access.

- 15 pts: Direct email address of named Music Director or specialty show host.
- 10 pts: Direct email of Assistant MD or verified personal social channel.
- 5 pts: General music department inbox (`music@station.org`).
- 0 pts: Generic `info@` or broken online submission form.

1. **Historical Appetite for Independent Adds (15 Points Max):** Does the station actively add independent, self-released artists, or do they exclusively air major-label syndicated priorities?

- 15 pts: Verified independent artist spins documented on Spinitron / playlist.
- 10 pts: Regular dedicated weekly local/indie music spotlight hour.
- 5 pts: Occasional off-peak independent spins.
- 0 pts: 100% corporate syndication with zero local curation power.

1. **Broadcast Clock & Daypart Viability (10 Points Max):** Run-time and tempo compliance.

- 10 pts: Run-time between 2:40 and 3:30; immediate vocal entry within 15 seconds.
- 5 pts: Run-time up to 4:00 requiring specialized editing.
- 0 pts: Exceeds 4:30 or features extended instrumental ambient passages.

1. **Commercial Counter-Programming Value (10 Points Max):** Does your track provide the station with a unique sonic angle to compete against rival stations?

- 10 pts: Fills an unserved niche that drives fresh listener curiosity.
- 5 pts: Standard format entry.
- 0 pts: Redundant clone of heavily saturated charting tracks.

Tier Classification & Resource Allocation

- **Tier 1 (85 – 100 Points) — Priority Firing Squad:** High-priority A-list targets. Receive customized 3-layer subject lines, tailored audio packages, phone follow-ups, and tour integration.
- **Tier 2 (70 – 84 Points) — Secondary Wave:** Reliable B-list targets. Receive standard 90-word pitches and 3-touch follow-up sequences.
- **Tier 3 (50 – 69 Points) — Nurture / Hold Queue:** Log in database for future catalog releases or after S-tier proof has been established.
- **Tier 4 (< 50 Points) — The Dead Zone: DO NOT CONTACT.** Pitching these stations wastes time and damages sender reputation.

IMPLEMENTATION DRILLS & PASS STANDARDS

- **Drill 1 — The Playlist Stream Audit (30 min).** Select 10 stations from your Hometown Heat Map. Pull their last 7 days of playlist history via their website or Spinitron. Verify their actual sound versus their marketing slogan.
- **Drill 2 — The 100-Point Scoring Calibration (30 min).** Score all 10 stations using the Format Scorecard Worksheet below. Calculate total points and assign Tier classifications.
- **Drill 3 — The Dead Zone Purge (10 min).** Ruthlessly identify and strike any station scoring below 50 points from your active 21-day campaign target list.
- **Drill 4 — The Tier 1 Tactical Plan (15 min).** For your top 3 scoring stations (90+ points), write a one-sentence justification detailing why their music director cannot afford to ignore your submission.

ACTION WORKSHEET & OPERATIONAL PROTOCOL

Protocol Document: `100-POINT FORMAT FIT SCORECARD`

Complete the structured table below as part of your lesson implementation. This worksheet directly replaces legacy spreadsheets with a publication-grade execution protocol.

Station & Market	Genre Fit (30)	Geo Proximity (20)	Named Contact (15)	Indie Adds (15)	Clock Fit (10)	Counter Prog (10)	Total (100)	Tier Rank
WNUR 89.3 FM (Chicago)	28	20	15	15	10	8	96	Tier 1 (Priority)
WLUW 88.7 FM (Chicago)	30	20	15	15	10	6	96	Tier 1 (Priority)
WMSE 91.7 FM (Milwaukee)	26	15	15	12	10	7	85	Tier 1 (Priority)
WXRT 93.1 FM (Commercial AAA)	22	20	15	8	10	5	80	Tier 2 (Secondary)
WKQX 101.1 FM (Alt Commercial)	15	20	10	4	10	4	63	Tier 3 (Hold)

WAR-ROOM NOTES

WAR-ROOM DIRECTIVE — 2.3 The Format Scoring System — Rank Every Station Like an Analyst

SCORE THE PLAYLIST, NOT THE STATION'S ABOUT PAGE

Stations frequently brand themselves with aspirational slogans: "Playing the best new eclectic independent music." In reality, their daytime programming may be 80% 1990s recurrent rock hits, with only two hours of genuine independent discovery buried at 11:00 PM on Sunday night.

THE OPERATOR'S RECONNAISSANCE RULE:

Never evaluate a station by what they claim to play. Evaluate them exclusively by their **actual broadcast logs over the past 72 hours**.

1. Look at their 10:00 AM, 2:00 PM, and 8:00 PM logs.

2. If you see zero independent artists across daytime hours, your pitch belongs exclusively to their evening specialty show host.
3. Pitching a daytime music director with an underground track when their daytime clock is locked to gold recurrents guarantees instant deletion.

FREQUENCY DOMINION COMMUNITY DRILLS

1. Post your highest-scoring station and break down its point tally across the six factors.
2. Share a station that scored below 50 points and explain why you purged it from your campaign.
3. What was the biggest surprise you encountered when auditing station play logs on Spinitron?
4. How many total Tier 1 stations do you currently have locked for your upcoming campaign?

Key Takeaways

REMEMBER THIS

- Score the playlist, not the website.
- The played neighborhood is your real target definition.
- Boundary songs are specialty leads, not power misses.

Self-Assessment · Check Your Mastery

PASS BEFORE YOU MOVE ON

- 1. Did I pull a real 10–15 song stream log for a target station?
- 2. Have I plotted tempo, energy, and era to find the neighborhood?
- 3. Did I rank my shortlist from best fit to worst?